

Apple offering custom configs for Macbooks in India

One of the biggest disparities between Apple's markets elsewhere and India was that in India, the company only launched specific configurations for their laptops. In most other markets, users enjoyed the ability to configure their Macs to their liking. Well, all that's started to change. According to TechCrunch, Apple retailers in India have started accepting orders for custom-configured Apple machines, with a lead-time of 4-5 weeks. What this means is that you no longer have to settle for the limited configurations that are normally listed on the Apple India website. For example, the brand new Apple MacBook Pro 13-inch can be configured using an 8th or 10th generation Intel processor, along with up to 32GB RAM and 2/4TB of storage. However, in India, users would have had to choose between pre-configured systems. Now, they can simply go to an Apple retailer

and order a custom-configured MacBook Pro 13-inch. This facility is available for all Apple computers.

It is interesting to see build-to-order systems being made available via retailers now. When we reviewed the 16-inch MacBook Pro, we had noted that Apple retailers in India could get custom configured builds of the laptop for customers, but that facility was available only for bulk/enterprise orders and required payment to be made in forex. The process now is not only much simpler but also open to everyone who wishes to use it.

The build-to-order facility comes via retailers just ahead of Apple launching its own webstore in India, with a physical store expected to

launch later next year. Apple's ambitions were confirmed by company CEO Tim Cook himself during an investor call earlier this year, saying that the company had been trying to work out the permissions with



the Indian Government. Despite the national lockdown brought on by the spread of COVID-19, it would appear that Apple is on track to realise its ambitions of a more substantial presence in India.

<https://dgit.in/cmacs>

Facebook launches Catchup, an audio only group calling app

As the world comes to grips with the Coronavirus outbreak, we've seen the rise of video calling applications as the most preferred means of communication. But, it looks like Facebook is bucking that trend with the launch of CatchUp. The app is a strictly audio-only app that can set up group calls with up to 8 people. Users also do not need to possess an account on Facebook to access the service as it works with your phone's contact list. It also lets you know when other users are available to talk.

The reason behind Facebook's decision to make CatchUp audio-only is a simple one. In a blog post, Nikki Shah, Product Lead on Facebook says, "Keeping in touch with friends and family is important, especially during this time of physical distancing. Messaging and video calling are great ways to send a quick update or connect with someone face-to-face, but speaking to

someone over the phone offers a unique balance of both convenience and personal connection. Based on our studies, we found that one of the main reasons people don't call friends and family more frequently is that they don't know when they are available to talk or are worried they may reach them at an inconvenient time. CatchUp addresses this problem and even makes group calling as easy as one tap."

The app is currently being tested out in the US for a limited time on iOS and Android and there is no word on when it'll come to other regions as of now. Facebook has been taking a few major strides in

India as well, as the company has reportedly invested \$5.7 billion in Reliance Jio Platforms. The social media giant has also bought Gif-making site GIPHY for \$400 million and plans to integrate the app with Instagram.

<https://dgit.in/catchup>

